

on a technique known as pixelisation, which drastically reduces the picture quality. Manufacturers will boast of 500x and 800x digital zoom. If you shoot at that number, your video will practically unwatchable. This is similar to the enlarge option in MS Paint: as the size of the picture increases, you just get to see the pixels more closely, rather than any actual close-up of the frame!

Optical zoom, on the other hand, relies on the physical movement of the lens assembly to enlarge the shot or bring long-range subjects closer. 10x optical zoom should do for most situations, and higher-end models may support 20x or even 30x zoom. Even at 10x, the zoom capability approaches telephoto shot quality of still cameras.



1.2.4. Still Photos

Much like digital cameras that offer you the capability of shooting video, camcorder manufacturers incorporate the ability to take still shots. This again is marketed as a major feature, but approach it with scepticism. The technology used to take still shots with digital cameras is radically different from the way a camcorder functions. Just as digital cameras do not take great videos, camcorders don't take great stills. Still-picture quality is measured in mega-pixels. In camcorders, the video quality is largely determined by the size of the CCD and effective pixels in the CCD. You should note that when a camcorder boasts 1 or 2 megapixel still picture capability, this in no way has a correlation to video quality. Do not misconstrue video quality to mean still picture quality. It is a better idea to go with a model without still shot capability and use a separate digital